

Chapter 34 - Part 4

Liang Shi was silent for a long time, and finally said quietly: "That's because what Aunt-in-law says always makes sense."

Little Bell looked at her disdainfully—Liar!

Liang Shi realized she was being despised by a child who was still in kindergarten. She struggled to maintain her dignity: "It really is! Isn't what Aunt-in-law says correct?"

"No." Little Bell looked at Xu Qingzhu: "Just now Aunt-in-law was clearly looking at you. The expression when thinking about something isn't like that."

To prove her point, Little Bell jumped off the sofa and imitated it perfectly.

First, she stared at the wall with vacant, dull eyes, then said: "When thinking about something, it's like this. But just now Aunt-in-law was clearly staring at you. I even saw Aunt-in-law swallow!"

Xu Qingzhu: "...???!!!"

Did she have no face left?

"Huh? Really?" Liang Shi was also surprised, but didn't dare think too much: "Impossible."

Little Bell nodded firmly: "Yes, there was."

"Aunt-in-law, you say it yourself." Little Bell said: "Adults can't lie to children."

Xu Qingzhu covered her forehead with her hand, slapping herself on the forehead so hard it made a loud sound. Liang Shi immediately said: "Little Bell, don't bully your aunt-in-law. Come play with Auntie."

"I wasn't bullying Aunt-in-law." Little Bell pouted: "Why do you adults always confuse concepts? You're not being sincere at all."

Liang Shi: "..."

Were children nowadays this hard to fool?

They knew way too much!

"Your aunt-in-law is shy." Liang Shi said: "If you keep talking like this, Aunt-in-law will want to burrow into the ground."

Little Bell was confused: "Why?"

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"Because Aunt-in-law likes me too much, but she's too embarrassed to admit it. When you say this, you expose Aunt-in-law's little thoughts." Liang Shi began making things up seriously: "Aunt-in-law has an introverted personality. She gets shy when she likes someone. Don't you?"

"No." Little Bell said matter-of-factly: "I like Shen Yiran¹ in our class, so I told her I like her."

Liang Shi: "...?"

"How old are you?" Liang Shi was shocked: "How can you tell other children you like them?"

"No matter what age, everyone has the right to like someone. Auntie, you're discriminating by age." Little Bell said dissatisfiedly: "I share my snacks with her, and I play with my favorite toys with her. And this little panda was also a gift from her. I don't even let others touch it."

Liang Shi felt her head was about to explode: "Does your mom know? This is a very serious matter. Children can't have puppy love."

Little Bell snorted lightly.

Xu Qingzhu spoke up at the right time: "She's just a child, what does she understand? Xu Qingya² said she wanted to marry their class monitor when she was in kindergarten too."

"What about now?" Liang Shi asked.

"They had a falling out before she even started elementary school." Xu Qingzhu said: "Don't misinterpret children's pure emotions with your thinking, okay? At most, they just like playing with this particular child, so they directly express their liking."

Liang Shi: "...Oh."

She had been narrow-minded.

She had been judging a gentleman's heart with a petty person's mind.

"But Shen Yiran and I have already bowed to heaven and earth³." Little Bell said: "This isn't a children's game. We're serious."

Liang Shi & Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Then the two looked at each other, both seeing disbelief and despair in each other's eyes.

"Bowed to heaven and earth? Where did you do it?" Liang Shi asked.

Little Bell answered matter-of-factly: "In our classroom! Many classmates were there, and we even gave them wedding candy."

Liang Shi: "...Does your mom know?"

"Yes." Little Bell said: "My mom has even met Shen Yiran."

If Sun Meirou knew, then it was fine.

But...

"What did your mom say?" Liang Shi asked.

Little Bell: "She told me to treat Shen Yiran well because her mom had a little sister, and Shen Yiran cried for several days."

Liang Shi didn't understand: "Why would she cry? Wouldn't having a little child in the family make her happy?"

"Because her mom always asks her to take care of her sister. She used to have very pretty hairstyles for school that her mom would do for her, but now her mom has to take care of the sister. She doesn't like letting the nanny aunt touch her hair, so she often comes to school with loose hair and cries during class. Last week when we got out of school, her mom scolded her at the school gate because she was being disobedient and wanted her mom to throw the sister away, or else she wouldn't go home." Little Bell sighed: "I think she's acting strange. If my mom had a little sister, I would definitely be a good big sister."

Liang Shi stroked her head: "Then tell your mom to have another one."

"But my mom won't have any more children." Little Bell said: "My mom bled a lot when she gave birth to me, and my dad cried terribly. I heard from my eldest aunt. Hehe."

Little Bell giggled secretly: "My dad said he would never let my mom have children again in this lifetime. Having me as his little princess is enough. And my mom's body still hasn't recovered well."

Liang Shi: "..."

Children nowadays really knew a lot.

Before she could speak to comfort her, Little Bell looked at her with bright eyes: "Auntie, why don't you two have a little child for me to play with?"

Liang Shi & Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Have a little child for her to play with?

"My mom likes children too. We can help you take care of them." Little Bell said happily: "If you're busy with work, you can foster the child at my house. If she's scared at night, I can sleep with her."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

She didn't understand, but was greatly shocked.

"Little Bell, who taught you to say this?" Xu Qingzhu reasonably suspected that the Liang family had started urging them to have children.

Were they dissatisfied that she hadn't gotten pregnant after marrying into the family for four months?

"Nobody taught me." Little Bell said innocently: "I really want a little sister to play with. A little brother would be fine too—I could use him as a punching bag."

Liang Shi: "...Little Bell, even if it's a brother, you can't bully him. Brothers can protect you when they grow up."

Little Bell shrugged indifferently: "Brothers are meant to be bullied."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Really, nobody taught you to say this?" Liang Shi couldn't help being curious too: "Did your grandma say something at home?"

"No." Little Bell thought for a moment, then suddenly paused, glancing at Xu Qingzhu guiltily, then whispering to Liang Shi in what she thought was an inaudible voice: "Grandma was talking on the phone before, saying that if you and Aunt-in-law don't divorce, she has no choice."

Liang Shi: "..."

Qiu Zimin⁴ was really "well-intentioned."

"I was curious so I asked Mom why they wanted you to divorce." Little Bell acted like a little spy, spilling all the information she knew from the old mansion.

"What did your mom say?" Liang Shi asked, suppressing her emotions.

Little Bell imitated her mother's tone, gentle but with thorns: "Children shouldn't meddle in adults' affairs."

Liang Shi: "..."

Then she caught Xu Qingzhu's meaningful gaze, as if saying—there's this twist too?

"But we're talking about you two!" Little Bell said with conviction: "When are you going to give me a little sister to play with?!"

Xu Qingzhu closed her laptop, got up from the sofa, her voice clear and cold, her tone calm yet indifferent: "Let your auntie have one. She's very capable."

Liang Shi: "?"

"I can't do it." Liang Shi said: "I can't manage that."

Little Bell listened in confusion: "Huh?"

Xu Qingzhu was almost gritting her teeth, yet maintaining her elegance on the surface: "You can do it. You're especially capable."

Liang Shi coughed lightly, feeling guilty, knowing that Xu Qingzhu had heard.

"You're two-faced, eloquent, saying one thing and doing another—you can do anything." Xu Qingzhu smiled calmly: "So having children, you can definitely do it."

Liang Shi: "..."

She mumbled: "I can't have one by myself."

Xu Qingzhu, who had almost reached the study door, turned back upon hearing this: "Soon there will be someone new to have children with you. Don't worry."

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Xu Qingzhu returned to the study.

Little Bell asked Liang Shi with a confused expression: "Auntie, is Aunt-in-law angry because of what I said? Doesn't Aunt-in-law want to have a little sister with you?"

Liang Shi had a mouthful of blood stuck in her throat, forcibly swallowing it down, and coaxed: "Your aunt-in-law is shy, she's not angry at you."

Little Bell: "Okay."

To prevent Little Bell from repeating things, Liang Shi had to say: "Your aunt-in-law and I just got married. It's not time for us to have children yet."

"Then when will it be time?" Little Bell asked.

Liang Shi: "...When we want to have children."

"Don't you want to now? Children are so cute." Little Bell cupped her own face: "Look at me, am I cute? My dad said after having me, he loved Mom even more because Mom gave him a little princess."

Liang Shi was left speechless, feeling on one hand that children nowadays were really hard to handle, and on the other hand finding the coquettish Little Bell so adorable that she would agree to whatever she said, even wanting to pluck stars from the sky for her.

After experiencing an internal battle between ice and fire, she said helplessly: "Someday we will want to."

Little Bell: "Which day is someday?"

Children's curiosity always exploded in strange places.

The persistent questioning left Liang Shi unable to cope. She could only divert Little Bell's attention, with the string still tangled in her hands: "Look at this, come untangle it."

Little Bell's attention was indeed diverted, and she continued playing cat's cradle with her.

Only then did Liang Shi breathe a sigh of relief.

But when she calmed down, she began to think: What was Xu Qingzhu angry about?

Was it because Qiu Zimin wanted them to divorce?

But didn't Xu Qingzhu also want a divorce?

Could it be that as someone who had always been a favored daughter of heaven, smooth sailing all her life, she only allowed herself to bring it up, but not others?

Liang Shi was deep in thought when Little Bell patted her: "Auntie, hurry up, don't zone out."

Liang Shi immediately snapped back: "Okay."

She was intimidated by this clever and mischievous little girl.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu, who had returned to the study with her laptop, first focused on finishing the proposal, then allowed herself to lie in the chair and think about what had just happened.

She had always been rational, so she inevitably had doubts about Little Bell's behavior.

Little Bell had never gotten along with Liang Shi before. They had been married for four months and had only met once at the wedding. Liang Shi rarely returned to the old mansion after marriage. How had Little Bell suddenly become close to her?

Even if it was because Liang Shi had become better and more likeable, why were Liang Xinhe and his wife so comfortable leaving Little Bell here?

After Little Bell arrived, she frequently brought up the topic of children. Even Sun Meirou had mentioned pregnancy at the door just now. Connecting all these details, it was indeed hard not to be suspicious.

But children were still children after all. They were young, and any thoughts they had were written plainly on their faces.

Just now, Xu Qingzhu had observed carefully, and Little Bell was simply expressing her thoughts sincerely.

For a moment, Xu Qingzhu didn't know whether to say her conspiracy theories were too advanced, or that the Liang family was too cunning.

She knew that the Liang family didn't like her marriage to Liang Shi.

In that entire family, the one who disliked her most was Qiu Zimin, even though Qiu Zimin was the first person to agree to let Liang Shi marry her, and also the first to switch sides and persuade Father Liang to invest in Minghui Jewelry.

But Qiu Zimin could be said to dote on Liang Shi. Every time Liang Shi caused trouble, she was the one who cleaned up the mess.

Over time, Liang Shi became increasingly reckless.

It seemed that Qiu Zimin really loved this daughter, but among the four children, the most spoiled and most useless was also this daughter.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe were both graduates of prestigious schools, finance prodigies who entered the company immediately after graduation. Liang Xinzhou could now handle things independently at Dongheng Group, and although Liang Wanwan⁵ was young and her grades weren't great, she studied painting and was accepted into the Painting Department of the Communication University. She had a quiet and reserved personality, quite the demeanor of a socialite.

Everyone said that Mrs. Liang was very good at educating children, with Liang Shi being the only failure.

Some people without tact would occasionally make snide remarks in front of Liang Shi, and Mrs. Liang would defend her: "My Ah Shi was born from my own hard labor. I just love her a bit too much. She hasn't done anything wrong. My Liang family's child—what's wrong with being a bit spoiled? Anyway, her two brothers are there to clean up after her."

People in their circle often said it was Mrs. Liang who had ruined Liang Shi.

But Liang Shi didn't think so, and relying on having someone to clean up after her, she became even more reckless.

Xu Qingzhu had always felt there was something wrong, but at that time she had a pile of problems herself. Just hesitating about whether to marry Liang Shi was already overwhelming, and she had no time to consider these matters.

Now thinking about it, there were indeed many suspicious points.

Why were all the children excellent, except for Liang Shi who was the failure?

Even Little Bell was extremely well-educated, and despite growing up in the old mansion, she had a very likeable personality.

When Mrs. Liang was the first to agree initially, why did she want them to divorce after just four months?

Her emotions had been a bit agitated just now, but now that she had calmed down, she felt she had been a bit excessive earlier.

Anyway, they were going to divorce. What difference did it make who brought it up?

The main thing was that when she thought this decision might have been made by Liang Shi in consultation with her mother, she felt... an indescribable tightness in her chest.

A few days ago, Mother Liang had arranged for Liang Shi to meet Zhou Yi'an again.

So the plan was to have them divorce within three months, then pair Liang Shi with Zhou Yi'an, even though Zhou Yi'an was a hidden-gender person?

Mother Liang was planning to completely ruin Liang Shi's reputation.

Although Liang Shi didn't have much of a reputation in their circle anyway.

But this kind of behavior really didn't seem like something a mother could do. If it were Liang Wanwan instead, Qiu Zimin would probably stop it immediately, very likely nipping it in the bud, and would definitely have Liang Wanwan marry someone from a family that matched the Liang family's status.

Yes, Liang Wanwan was an Omega.

And Liang Shi, marrying a wife, could marry into an already declining family.

At that time, a joke circulated in their circle: Third Miss Liang, in a fit of anger for a beauty, would rather abandon the Lin family's hundreds of millions in assets and forsake her flower-like childhood sweetheart, just to fly together with her beloved.

Almost no one in their circle had this kind of courage.

After all, this circle seemed glamorous and magnificent, but everyone depended on their families.

When families prospered, individuals prospered; when families declined, individuals declined.

Status reversals could happen overnight, so one had to be cautious and careful at every step, not daring to make a single mistake.

So what love was there in this circle? Wasn't it all business marriages?

As long as it was good for the enterprise and the family, what need was there for love?

This circle had a lot of money, but very little love.

Liang Shi's behavior at that time seemed foolish to everyone—blatant poverty alleviation.

But she was helping the "Number One Omega of Haicheng," so it seemed profitable too.

Footnotes:

¹ Shen Yiran: Little Bell's classmate and "girlfriend"

² Xu Qingya: Xu Qingzhu's younger sister

³ Bowed to heaven and earth: A traditional Chinese wedding ceremony ritual

⁴ Qiu Zimin: Liang Shi's adoptive mother, Mrs. Liang

⁵ Liang Wanwan: Liang Shi's youngest sister